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Deaf Awareness Month Classroom Pack

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FOR THE GENERAL-EDUCATION CLASSROOM, SEPTEMBER AND YEAR-ROUND

DEAF AWARENESS MONTH CLASSROOM PACK

Deaf Awareness Month is recognized every September — a chance for a classroom that includes a Deaf or hard-of-hearing (DHH) student, or simply wants to understand more, to learn the basics: how people communicate, what helps in the room, and how to be a good classmate. This pack describes DHH learners in general; it is not about, and never names, any specific student.

What Deaf Awareness Month is

Deaf Awareness Month grows out of International Week of the Deaf, established by the World Federation of the Deaf (WFD) and marked worldwide in the last full week of September. September 23 is International Day of Sign Languages, recognized by the United Nations since 2018 and chosen because it is the date the WFD itself was founded, in 1951. In the United States, the National Association of the Deaf (NAD) promotes the whole month as a chance for schools and communities to learn about Deaf culture, sign languages, and the everyday experience of Deaf and hard-of-hearing people.

Ways people communicate

Deaf and hard-of-hearing people communicate in more than one way, and no path on this list is more correct than another. A student gets to this classroom however they communicate — the room's job is to work with that, not to expect one approach over the rest.

American Sign Language (ASL)

A full, complex visual-spatial language with its own grammar — not a coded or simplified version of English.

Listening and spoken language

Some students use hearing technology (hearing aids, cochlear implants) and listening-and-spoken-language practice to develop spoken English or another spoken language.

Bimodal / combined approaches

Some students and families use sign and spoken language together — for example, signing at home and speaking at school, or using both in the same conversation.

No hearing devices

Some Deaf and hard-of-hearing people use no hearing technology at all, communicating through sign language, lipreading, writing, or a combination.

Communication-repair strategies

Every classroom has moments where something doesn't get across the first time. What the adult in the room does next matters more than what happened.

Rephrase it — different words, not the same sentence said louder.

Write the key words on the board or hand them over on paper.

Confirm privately that the repair worked, rather than assuming it did.

Classroom access: quick wins

Face the student when you're speaking — not the board, not your screen.

One person speaks at a time. Overlapping voices are the hardest listening situation there is.

Captions on, every video, every time — checked before you press play.

Check the acoustics — soft surfaces (rugs, curtains, felt on chair feet) cut down echo, and background noise from hallways or equipment can be reduced more than most rooms assume.

Fingerspelling: what it is and why it matters

Fingerspelling is spelling a word out letter by letter using a manual alphabet — in the United States, the American Manual Alphabet used within ASL. Signers fingerspell names, places, and words that don't yet have an established sign, or to clarify a word that was misunderstood. A classroom can support this without learning it: pre-teach new or unusual vocabulary in writing ahead of time, so a word isn't being fingerspelled cold in the middle of a lesson. For an accurate reference chart, look to Deaf-led sources such as Gallaudet University or the National Association of the Deaf rather than a general web image search — the shape of a handshape matters, and it's easy to find an inaccurate one.